

September 7, 2026

PE6011 Political Economy^{1 2}**Thu 18:20 - 21:00****Seminar Room A**

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Course Description

This class is intended to give a broad overview of topics and methods used in political economy. Since the field of political economy is vast and multifaceted, we will pay attention to the two most common understandings of political economy. The first sees political economy as concerned with studying interrelationships between political and economic processes. The second defines political economy as a set of analytical tools that can be used to understand a wide range of political phenomena. In practice, there is a give and take between the two approaches since the questions we ask are influenced by the analytical tools at our disposal and vice versa. Thus, the class introduces classic topics such as redistribution, democratization, and the relationship between economic performance and voting behavior. It also presents the analysis of political and economic institutions from a rationalist perspective. Students should come out of this course with a better understanding of how a political economist thinks and what kind of puzzles they generally find interesting. What this course will not do, given the obvious time limitations, is to provide an up-to-date summary of the current state of the field, nor compare and contrast this research vein with others prevalent in political science.

While this course will cover some game-theoretic and formal theories, previous knowledge of such methods is not required nor expected. I will at times go over the main logic and basic mathematical structure of certain models, but this is categorically not a formal theory course. The course is designed to provide students with the conceptual tools and theoretical background needed to independently engage with recent work in political economy and ultimately integrate political economy perspectives into their thinking. Students wanting to learn the methodology of formal modeling and game theory should come to see me at my office or take an appropriate course.

Prerequisites: None.**Credits:** 3.0**Text:** There is no required textbook, but see the assigned readings each week.

¹Applicable to the part-time (in-service) master's program.

²The instructor reserves the right to make reasonable changes to the syllabus and class schedule during the course of the semester. Please refer to my website <https://yitalu.github.io> for the most updated version.

Course Requirements and Evaluation

1. **Preparation and Discussion Questions (20%):** Students are expected to read the assigned articles from the Class Schedule and submit two discussion questions before each class. The amount of the assigned readings typically includes four to six articles per week. The discussion questions should be emailed to your classmates and the instructor by *6:00 pm the day before class*. The discussion questions should be thoughtful and critical, and should not be simple factual questions.

The discussion questions will be graded on a pass/fail basis (1 or 0). No late submission will be accepted. Since there are 14 weeks of readings and thus 28 discussion questions in total, students can miss up to 8 discussion questions without penalty. If you submit discussion questions for more than 10 weeks, the extra submissions will not be counted toward your grade. No late submissions will be accepted.

2. **Participation (30%):** Students are expected to participate actively in seminar discussions by engaging critically with the readings, raising questions, and responding thoughtfully to classmates. Contributions may include summarizing an article; outlining its central argument and key concepts; identifying its strengths and limitations; explaining points of agreement or disagreement; relating readings to one's own research interests; and comparing readings to develop a broader understanding of the field.

This seminar is a respectful space for open discussion. Everyone brings different backgrounds and perspectives, and all sincere questions are welcome. Please share your ideas respectfully and avoid comments that offend or put down others.

Participation is evaluated primarily on quality rather than quantity, including intellectual substance, analytical insight, and constructive engagement. The instructor will moderate discussion and clarify key concepts and debates as needed.

3. **Response Papers (20%):** For any two weeks of your choice, students are required to submit a 2-3 page response paper (double-spaced, 12-point font) that critically engages with the discussion of that week. The purpose of the response paper is to encourage students to *reflect* on issues raised in and insights gained from the seminar discussion. It is designed to help students synthesize the readings and class discussion, deepen their understanding of the material, develop their own perspectives on weekly topics, and thus focus on the bigger picture instead of the specifics of any particular readings.

Response papers are due two weeks after the class in which the readings were discussed. Late submissions will still be accepted but with a 1% deduction per day.

4. **Research Proposal (30%):** Students will present a research proposal on a topic of their choice related to political economy and submit a written version of the proposal. The proposal is intended to help students explore a research question of interest and may serve as an early step toward a future research paper or dissertation.

The proposal should include a clear research question, a review of relevant literature, a theoretical framework, and a proposed methodology. Students will deliver a 8-10 minute presentation in Week 16 (December 24, 2026), followed by a Q&A session. Presentations should

be clear, concise, and demonstrate a deep understanding of the topic; slides or handouts may be used but are not required.

Drawing on feedback from classmates and the instructor, students will revise the proposal and submit a final written version of 10-15 double-spaced pages, in 12-point font, by 11:59 pm on January 7, 2027, the last day of class. No late submissions will be accepted. The proposal will be evaluated based on the clarity and significance of the research question, the depth and breadth of the literature review, the soundness of the theoretical framework, and the feasibility and rigor of the proposed methodology.

The oral presentation is worth 10% of the final grade, and the final written proposal is worth 20%.

Course Policies

1. **Laptop and Electronic Devices:** You may use laptop or any electronic devices *only* for reading the assigned materials in the class. All devices that make noise must be put on silent/vibrate mode upon entering the classroom. If usage of electronic devices becomes a distraction in the class, I reserve the right to ask you to leave or take your points off.
2. **AI Policy:** AI tools may NOT be used during class discussion. Students are expected to read the assigned materials, develop their own questions, and participate in discussion based on their own understanding and analysis.

AI tools may be used outside of class for the purpose of clarifying unfamiliar terms or translating short passages. However, students are prohibited from using AI to generate arguments or discussion questions, create presentations, and draft response papers and research proposals. Any use of AI for these purposes will be considered academic misconduct and will be subject to disciplinary action.

3. **Important Dates:**

- Discussion Questions: 6:00 pm every Wednesday (the day before seminar discussions)
- Response Papers: 11:59 pm on Thursday (two weeks after the seminar discussion)
- Research Proposal Presentation: Th 12/24, 2026
- Research Proposal Due: Th 1/7, 2027

4. **Communicating with the Instructor:** Outside of class time, every announcement will be made on Moodle or through email. The Moodle Course Site can be accessed at <https://moodle.ncku.edu.tw>. It is your responsibility to check them regularly. If you have any question, feel free to email me or see me during office hours, but please make sure there is no answer on the syllabus before contacting me. In addition, do not expect an immediate response via email. Normally, a response will be sent within 1 to 2 days.

Class Schedule

Week 1: Introduction and Syllabus Overview

Week 2: What is Political Economy?

- Weingast, B. R. and Wittman, D. A. (2006). The reach of political economy. In Weingast, B. R. and Wittman, D. A., editors, *The Oxford Handbook of Political Economy*, pages 3–28. Oxford University Press, Oxford
- Caporaso, J. A. and Levine, D. P. (1992). *Theories of Political Economy*. Cambridge University Press. Intro, Ch. 1
- Friedman, M. (1953). *Essays in positive economics*. University of Chicago press
- Riker, W. H. (1990). Political science and rational choice. *Perspectives on positive political economy*, pages 163–81
- Clarke, K. A. and Primo, D. M. (2007). Modernizing political science: A model-based approach. *Perspectives on Politics*, 5(4):741–753

Week 3: Rational Choice: Critiques and Defenses

- Green, D. and Shapiro, I. (1994). *Pathologies of rational choice theory: A critique of applications in political science*. Yale University Press. Ch. 1-3
- Cox, G. W. (1999). The empirical content of rational choice theory: A reply to green and shapiro. *Journal of Theoretical Politics*, 11(2):147–169
- Lovett, F. (2006). Rational choice theory and explanation. *Rationality and Society*, 18(2):237–272
- Green, D. and Shapiro, I. (2005). Revisiting the pathologies of rational choice. *The flight from reality in the human sciences*, pages 51–99

Week 4: Models of Political Competition

- Downs, A. (1957). An economic theory of democracy. Ch. 2-4, 8
- Bueno de Mesquita, B., Smith, A., Siverson, R. M., and Morrow, J. D. (2003). *The logic of political survival*. The MIT press. Ch. 2-3

Week 5: Why Institutions?

- Coase, R. H. (1960). The problem of social cost. *The journal of Law and Economics*, 3:1–44
- Olson, M. (1967). *The logic of collective action*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 1
- Ostrom, E. (1990). *Governing the commons: The evolution of institutions for collective action*. Cambridge university press. Ch. 1-2

- North, D. C. (1993). Institutions and credible commitment. *Journal of Institutional and Theoretical Economics*, 149(1):11–23
- Acemoglu, D. (2003). Why not a political coase theorem? social conflict, commitment, and politics. *Journal of comparative economics*, 31(4):620–652

Week 6: Models of Institutions

- Axelrod, R. (1981). The emergence of cooperation among egoists. *American political science review*, 75(2):306–318
- Milgrom, P. R., North, D. C., and Weingast*, B. R. (1990). The role of institutions in the revival of trade: The law merchant, private judges, and the champagne fairs. *Economics & Politics*, 2(1):1–23
- Ostrom, E. (2000). Collective Action and the Evolution of Social Norms. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 14(3):137–158
- Gülerk, Ö., Irlenbusch, B., and Rockenbach, B. (2006). The competitive advantage of sanctioning institutions. *Science*, 312(5770):108–111
- Henrich, J., McElreath, R., Barr, A., Ensminger, J., Barrett, C., Bolyanatz, A., Cardenas, J. C., Gurven, M., Gwako, E., Henrich, N., Lesorogol, C., Marlowe, F., Tracer, D., and Ziker, J. (2006). Costly punishment across human societies. *Science*, 312(5781):1767–1770

Week 7: Institutional Change

- David, P. A. (1985). Clio and the economics of QWERTY. *The American Economic Review*, 75(2):332–337
- Pierson, P. (2000). Increasing returns, path dependence, and the study of politics. *American political science review*, 94(2):251–267
- North, D. C. and Weingast, B. R. (1989). Constitutions and commitment: The evolution of institutions governing public choice in seventeenth-century England. *The Journal of Economic History*, 49(4):803–832
- Greif, A. and Laitin, D. (2004). A theory of endogenous institutional change. *American Political Science Review*, 98(4):633–52
- Thelen, K. (2003). How institutions evolve: Insights from comparative historical analysis. In Mahoney, J. and Rueschemeyer, D., editors, *Comparative Historical Analysis in the Social Sciences*, pages 208–240. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 5-6

Week 8: Electoral Institutions

- Carey, J. M. and Shugart, M. S. (1995). Incentives to cultivate a personal vote: A rank ordering of electoral formulas. *Electoral studies*, 14(4):417–439
- Cox, G. W. (1997). *Making votes count: strategic coordination in the world's electoral systems*. Cambridge University Press. Ch 2-3, 10-11

- Persson, T. and Tabellini, G. (1999). The size and scope of government:: Comparative politics with rational politicians. *European economic review*, 43(4-6):699–735
- Boix, C. (1999). Setting the rules of the game: the choice of electoral systems in advanced democracies. *American political science review*, 93(3):609–624
- Cusack, T. R., Iversen, T., and Soskice, D. (2007). Economic interests and the origins of electoral systems. *American Political Science Review*, 101(3):373–391

Week 9: Clientelism and Distributive Politics

- Stokes, S. C., Dunning, T., Nazareno, M., and Brusco, V. (2013). *Brokers, voters, and clientelism: The puzzle of distributive politics*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 1, 3
- Wantchekon, L. (2003). Clientelism and voting behavior: Evidence from a field experiment in Benin. *World Politics*, 55(3):399–422
- Nichter, S. (2008). Vote buying or turnout buying? Machine politics and the secret ballot. *American Political Science Review*, 102(1):19–31
- Keefer, P. (2007). Clientelism, credibility, and the policy choices of young democracies. *American Journal of Political Science*, 51(4):804–821
- Ross, M. L. (1999). The political economy of the resource curse. *World politics*, 51(2):297–322

Week 10: The Economy and the Vote

- Fearon, J. D. (1999). Electoral accountability and the control of politicians: selecting good types versus sanctioning poor performance. *Democracy, accountability, and representation*, 55:61
- MacKuen, M. B., Erikson, R. S., and Stimson, J. A. (1992). Peasants or bankers? the american electorate and the us economy. *American Political Science Review*, 86(3):597–611
- Powell Jr, G. B. and Whitten, G. D. (1993). A cross-national analysis of economic voting: taking account of the political context. *American Journal of Political Science*, pages 391–414
- Kayser, M. A. and Peress, M. (2012). Benchmarking across borders: Electoral accountability and the necessity of comparison. *American Political Science Review*, 106(3):661–684
- Healy, A. and Malhotra, N. (2013). Retrospective voting reconsidered. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 16:285–306

Week 11: Distribution, Inequality, and Welfare States

- Boix, C. et al. (2003). *Democracy and redistribution*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 1-2
- Iversen, T. and Soskice, D. (2006). Electoral institutions and the politics of coalitions: Why some democracies redistribute more than others. *American Political Science Review*, 100(2):165–181

- Esping-Andersen, G. (1990). *The three worlds of welfare capitalism*. Princeton University Press. Ch. 1
- Scheve, K. and Stasavage, D. (2009). Institutions, partisanship, and inequality in the long run. *World Politics*, 61(2):215–253
- Shayo, M. (2009). A model of social identity with an application to political economy: Nation, class, and redistribution. *American Political Science Review*, 103(2):147–174

Week 12: Development and Democratization

- Przeworski, A. and Limongi, F. (1997). Modernization: Theories and facts. *World politics*, 49(2):155–183
- Boix, C. and Stokes, S. C. (2003). Endogenous democratization. *World Politics*, 55(4):517–549
- Acemoglu, D. and Robinson, J. A. (2000). Why did the West extend the franchise? Democracy, inequality, and growth in historical perspective. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 115(4):1167–1199
- Acemoglu, D., Johnson, S., and Robinson, J. A. (2001). The colonial origins of comparative development: An empirical investigation. *American economic review*, 91(5):1369–1401
- Inglehart, R. and Welzel, C. (2005). *Modernization, Cultural Change, and Democracy: The Human Development Sequence*. Cambridge University Press. Ch. 1, 7

Week 13: The Political Economy of Globalization

- Rogowski, R. (1987). Political cleavages and changing exposure to trade. *American Political Science Review*, 81(4):1121–1137
- Hiscox, M. J. (2001). Class versus industry cleavages: inter-industry factor mobility and the politics of trade. *International Organization*, 55(1):1–46
- Rodrik, D. (1998). Why do more open economies have bigger governments? *Journal of political economy*, 106(5):997–1032
- Scheve, K. and Slaughter, M. J. (2004). Economic insecurity and the globalization of production. *American Journal of Political Science*, 48(4):662–674
- Farrell, H. and Newman, A. L. (2019). Weaponized interdependence: How global economic networks shape state coercion. *International Security*, 44(1):42–79

Week 14: Behavioral and Evolutionary Approaches

- Wilson, R. K. (2011). The contribution of behavioral economics to political science. *Annual Review of Political Science*, 14(1):201–223
- McDermott, R., Fowler, J. H., and Smirnov, O. (2008). On the evolutionary origin of prospect theory preferences. *The Journal of Politics*, 70(2):335–350

- Alford, J. R. and Hibbing, J. R. (2004). The origin of politics: An evolutionary theory of political behavior. *Perspectives on politics*, 2(4):707–723
- Claessens, S., Fischer, K., Chaudhuri, A., Sibley, C. G., and Atkinson, Q. D. (2020). The dual evolutionary foundations of political ideology. *Nature human behaviour*, 4(4):336–345
- Milinski, M., Sommerfeld, R. D., Krambeck, H.-J., Reed, F. A., and Marotzke, J. (2008). The collective-risk social dilemma and the prevention of simulated dangerous climate change. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 105(7):2291–2294

Week 15: Contemporary Frontiers in Political Economy

- Acemoglu, D. and Johnson, S. (2023). *Power and Progress: Our Thousand-Year Struggle over Technology and Prosperity*. Blackstone Pub. Prologue, Ch. 8-9
- Crawford, K. (2021). *Atlas of AI: Power, Politics, and the Planetary Costs of Artificial Intelligence*. Yale University Press. Intro, Ch. 6
- Rodrik, D. (2018). Populism and the economics of globalization. *Journal of International Business Policy*, 1(1–2):12–33

Week 16: Research Proposal Presentation

Week 17: Research Proposal Writing (No Class)

Week 18: Research Proposal Due (No Class)

Academic Integrity Statement

Each student must pursue his or her academic goals honestly and be personally accountable for all submitted work. Academic misconduct like cheating on exams, plagiarism, fabrication of information or citations, unauthorized collaboration, submitting the work of another person, or using work previously submitted for another course without prior authorization, is not tolerated and will be handled in accordance with university regulations. For more comprehensive information on academic integrity, please refer to the Office of Academic Integrity website at <https://oai.web2.ncku.edu.tw>.

Critical Incident and Emergency Management

In the event of a campus emergency, earthquake, or fire, follow the instructions of the instructor and proceed calmly to the designated evacuation assembly area. For urgent campus safety issues or critical incidents, contact the NCKU Campus Security Center, 06-2757575 ext. 55555, immediately.